CHAPTER VI

The Cruelty in Letting Go

Kolkata · September-October 2023

“Perhaps the cruellest moments are not those in which something is taken from us, but those in which we willingly give up what we most wish to keep. We do so gently, sometimes even gladly, believing that another person’s comfort matters more than our own desire. And only afterward, when the moment has passed and the world has resumed its ordinary course, do we discover how much of ourselves had wanted it to remain.”

Utkarsh returned to Kolkata a few days after Raksha Bandhan, carrying a bag that was lighter than when he had left. He had given his sister the present. That part of the afternoon had reached its intended destination.

At home, there had been meals at familiar hours, conversations interrupted and resumed without explanation, the comfort of being somewhere that required so little of him. Yet now and then he had found himself back in the shopping complex: Sanondita holding up a garment, her belongings gathered in his hands, her laughter arriving before he understood what he had said to deserve it.

He had told no one about the outing. A friend had helped him choose a gift. They had talked, laughed, and gone home. He could give a perfectly accurate account of it without explaining why he remembered so much.

On the journey back, he watched houses pass beyond the window and wondered whether she remembered the shop. Perhaps only the question about the missing bottom. That would be fair; he had contributed little else to the purchase. He smiled, then found himself hoping she had thought of it while he was away.

By the time he returned to coaching, September had begun. The ceiling fans continued their uneven labour. Students arrived with the same complaints about unfinished work and examinations that seemed perpetually nearer than anyone wished. Sanondita was in her usual place, attending to something in her notebook.

He saw her before she saw him. For a moment he remained near the doorway. He had expected to find her there; expectation had not prepared him for the small relief of actually doing so.

When he approached, she looked up. They greeted each other, exchanged a few words, and he took the place beside her. She was neither unusually attentive nor distant. He could put down his bag and join the conversation as though he had missed no part of it.

He was relieved, and a little disappointed. What had he expected? Some acknowledgement that he had been remembering her in another town? She had no way of knowing. He opened his notebook before his face could betray the unreasonable nature of the welcome he had briefly imagined.

A few minutes into the lesson, she leaned towards him and asked about the material. He pointed to the relevant line. She nodded, returned to her notes, and the exchange was over. He had missed even that: being close enough for a question to reach him quietly, answering before the teacher moved on.

For the first time since leaving Kolkata, there was nowhere else he wished to be.

September settled into afternoons he did not think to count. Sometimes he arrived first and looked towards the doorway at approaching footsteps. Sometimes she was already there, her books spread out, with something to tell him before he had opened his bag. They talked at length or hardly at all, depending on the lesson. A silence no longer sent him searching for what he had done wrong.

Tanisha and Nikita still exchanged news and complaints with him. Deepesh remained part of the familiar voices before class. Utkarsh stopped to talk, joined their laughter, and eventually returned to his place beside Sanondita. No one had quarrelled. Only

later did he notice that he now heard some stories after the others had finished telling them to one another.

Basavi was no longer attending coaching. She continued preparing at home, and he stayed in touch, sending notes or helping her catch up when she needed it. During one of their conversations, he learned that she had given birth to a daughter.

He mentioned the news to Sanondita. Her interest was immediate.

“A baby girl?”

He nodded.

“Do you have a picture?”

He did not. She asked whether he could get one, and later he messaged Basavi. When the photograph arrived, he remembered to show Sanondita at their next class.

She smiled as she looked at the baby’s face. He recognised the delight that entered her voice whenever she spoke about little girls. There were questions about the child; he answered what he knew and admitted how little that was. For once, the limitations of his information were of greater interest to her than anything he might have thought to say.

He was glad he had asked for the picture. Basavi, whom he had once sat beside, was preparing for examinations with a daughter at home. He wondered how she found the time. Sanondita looked at the photograph a moment longer before the lesson called them back.

The days held such things: news brought from elsewhere, a page shared, his name spoken before he realised she wanted him. One afternoon, while putting away his books, he noticed that he had spent the class answering, disagreeing, and laughing without stopping to judge each contribution. He could no longer recall exactly what they had discussed. He remembered enjoying it.

He watched her close her notebook. There were still things he could not tell her, but he had begun to have afternoons that were

pleasant while he lived them. He did not have to wait until he was alone to discover that he had been happy.

October arrived without quite persuading the rain to leave. On his way to coaching, the fragrance of shiuli sometimes reached him before he saw the white flowers beneath a wall, their orange stems scattered across the damp ground. The early coolness seldom lasted. By noon, buses carried their familiar burdens through the heat, and a clear morning had proved very little about the rest of the day.

An umbrella became something he put in his bag with his books. He grew accustomed to its weight, just as he grew accustomed to finding Sanondita beside him several afternoons a week. Then she would look up impatiently at an explanation that had wandered too far from its point, or turn a page while holding her place in another book, and he would catch himself watching.

How can you be so familiar and still do that?

He knew she would have no idea what he meant. She had only turned a page. He returned to his work.

Occasionally he wondered what would happen if she knew how often these small distractions followed him home. Would she become careful about what she said? Would she pause before handing him something or asking whether he was coming tomorrow? He disliked imagining that pause. He wanted to tell her enough to be understood and keep every freedom that came with her not knowing.

The wish remained a wish. When she spoke, he answered. Outside, shopkeepers examined skies that had darkened without warning, and rain left shallow puddles along the roadside. His umbrella stayed in his bag.

On the morning of the walk, the weather had been clear enough to leave it at home. He took it anyway. By the time he reached coaching, clouds had gathered above the buildings and the light entering the classroom had grown pale. Air from a partly open window lifted the corner of a loose page.

Sanondita was looking through earlier notes. When she found the explanation she wanted, she moved the notebook towards him and asked whether he remembered it. He did, although not with quite the confidence his answer suggested.

Their notes appeared to disagree. He studied both versions, trying to discover how the same lesson had produced such different results. Sanondita pointed to a number on his page. He had copied it incorrectly.

“That explains it,” he said.

“It does.”

He corrected the figure. The method recovered its reputation; his notebook did not. She was still smiling when the lesson began.

For a while he followed the teacher, worked through the questions, and checked his answers. The first low roll of thunder reached the room from beyond the buildings. A few students looked towards the windows. The teacher continued speaking. Utkarsh returned to his calculation.

The next rumble was closer. Across the road, the buildings had lost their sharp outlines beneath the gathering cloud. Sanondita turned towards the window.

“It looks like it’s going to rain.”

“Probably.”

He glanced at his bag. The umbrella was folded into its narrow sleeve beside his books. A sensible precaution, for once requiring no further thought.

Drops began striking the window ledge. At first he could hear them separately; then they became a continuous rush. Someone near the back rose to close a window. Bags were moved away from the wall, and the room acquired the smell of damp concrete. The teacher raised his voice.

Outside, water poured from a shop awning and broke against the pavement. Utkarsh watched it briefly. He liked rain when he could observe it without considering what it would do to his clothes and

notes. Today he had brought an umbrella. Beside him, Sanondita returned to her work, and he did the same.

By the end of class, the usual scraping of chairs and conversation seemed to come from beneath the weather. Students packed slowly. Some stood at the windows, assessing whether to wait; others produced umbrellas with the satisfaction of people whose precautions had been justified.

Utkarsh put away his books. Sanondita closed her notebook, checked that she had left nothing behind, and took a small umbrella from her bag. They joined the movement towards the door. Beyond it, rain fell in thick, slanting lines. Passing vehicles sent water towards the pavement, and the afternoon seemed to have misplaced several hours.

“Did you bring your umbrella?” she asked.

He almost said yes.

The answer was there, ready. So was the umbrella, against the side of his bag. He looked from hers to the rain and understood, before he had decided what to do, that there was another answer available.

With two umbrellas they would leave as usual. With one, perhaps she would let him walk beside her towards the station. A little farther than the doorway. A few minutes in which class was over and he would still have a reason to remain.

She was waiting for a simple answer. His hesitation was beginning to make it something else.

“No,” he said.

She heard him beneath the rain. Nothing changed in her expression. He had made the decision so quickly that the discomfort arrived after the word, when it was already something she believed. It was not the first time. Once before he had told her something was at home when it was against his side, and she had believed him that day as well.

He could correct himself. Say he had forgotten it was in his bag. The correction would be awkward for a moment, then the moment

would pass. He knew where the umbrella lay well enough that he could have reached it without looking.

Instead, he asked whether she could help him get towards the station.

Sanondita agreed. Simply, without hesitation. He thanked her, conscious of the unopened bag against his side, and followed her to the doorway. She had made it easy to ask. He was happy enough to wish he could stop thinking about why.

The umbrella opened with a small, stubborn click. She stepped out, and he followed after a motorcycle had sent its spray across the edge of the pavement. The rain struck harder here than it had appeared to through the window. Water rose from the road in a fine mist; thunder moved slowly above the buildings.

“Come under,” she said, shifting the umbrella towards him.

He stepped closer. There was scarcely enough room for both of them. He kept his arm at his side and matched her pace, trying to judge the distance at which he could share the shelter without crowding her. She was watching the pavement for somewhere to put her feet.

“It’s raining so heavily.”

“Yes.”

Usually he would have found more to say. Now he was trying to remember how he ordinarily walked. His bag seemed to occupy more space than it had inside. Each time he made room for it, rain caught his sleeve. Sanondita moved the handle towards him, and he shifted back so that she remained covered.

After a short distance, he asked whether he could hold the umbrella. She passed it to him. Her fingers released the curved grip; his closed around it. He raised it to accommodate his height and tilted the canopy towards her.

Rain began collecting on his right shoulder. At first he felt separate cold spots, then a dampness spreading down his upper arm. He could bring the handle back a little. Instead, he looked ahead and kept it where it was.

Sanondita was talking about how suddenly the rain had begun, searching for a clear stretch of pavement as she spoke. He answered. When a vehicle sent water towards them, he moved the umbrella to shield her from the spray.

She thanked him.

You needn't, he thought. You have no idea how little this is costing me.

The next gust drove rain against his collar. He discovered that the thought required some qualification. His shirt was cold, the bag strap damp against his chest, and his right arm had begun to stick unpleasantly to his side. He adjusted his grip without moving the shelter away from her.

He had imagined time together outside coaching before they ever went shopping. Those imagined afternoons generally supplied him with something worth saying. Here there was broken concrete, water running around their shoes, and a conversation he occasionally had to ask her to repeat because a bus drowned it out. He would not have exchanged it for anything he had rehearsed.

She stopped at a stretch where water had gathered across most of the pavement. A narrow edge remained beside a closed shop.

"Can we go that way?"

"I think so."

He tested the uneven ground first. As he stepped around the puddle, the umbrella tipped and rain struck his face. He steadied it, waited for her to cross, and fell into step beside her again. The delay could not have lasted half a minute. He was sorry when it ended.

What has become of you? You are pleased because the drains are blocked.

He looked at the road, almost smiling. There was no respectable answer to that.

Their conversation came in fragments. Between them he heard her footsteps quicken near puddles, the hiss of tyres, rain striking the canopy close above his head. She held her bag against her side

to protect its contents. Once the wind lifted loose strands of hair near her face before the damp settled them again.

He looked away before looking became noticeable. He wanted to remember the walk and was afraid that paying so much attention to remembering would make him miss what she was saying.

She was talking about the unpredictable weather. He answered, asked something, and listened to her reply. A perfectly ordinary conversation had survived the difficulty he was making of it. That comfort touched him more than the closeness he had obtained. He could be beside her without having to keep her entertained every second.

Then his own umbrella shifted against the books in his bag. He remembered the doorway and her straightforward question. He had wanted a reason to join her, and she had trusted the reason he supplied. The pleasure did not disappear. It became harder to enjoy without also noticing the weight against his side.

His right shoulder was thoroughly wet. When the wind strengthened, he shifted the canopy a fraction farther towards her. She did not seem to notice. He wondered what she would do if he pointed it out. Perhaps ask him to move closer; perhaps insist that he take more shelter. He could already imagine the concern in her voice.

He kept quiet. He had chosen the angle. Asking her to remedy it would give her another difficulty he could have spared her himself.

Ahead, the road curved towards the busier streets leading to the station. He knew the buildings well enough to judge the remaining distance without counting steps. Usually this was useful. Today each familiar shop told him something he did not want to know.

Could the road be a little longer?

Sanondita was watching for a dry place to step. He held the umbrella steady and went with her.

The rain lost some of its violence, though none of its persistence. It fell in a slanting curtain, gathering along the broken edges of the

pavement and slipping into the channels beside the road. Electric signs had begun to show against the dark shopfronts.

Utkarsh's fingers were stiff around the handle. He shifted the strap that had begun to dig into his wet shoulder. Sanondita noticed.

"Is your bag heavy?"

"A little."

"Do you want to stop?"

"No, it's all right."

She accepted his answer. They continued, and he found himself remembering the offer. She had noticed something was wrong and been willing to wait. He wanted to tell her that the bag hardly mattered, that there was very little about the afternoon he would choose to make more comfortable if it meant ending it sooner. Instead, he settled the strap and asked her to repeat what she had been saying before.

Ahead, the road widened near a crossing. Beyond it lay the stretch towards the station. He had walked this route often enough without once wishing to misunderstand its direction. Now he recognised every building and felt each recognition shorten the walk.

Sanondita wondered whether the rain would last into the evening. He thought it might. She said the weather had been strange lately, and he agreed. Later, he knew, he would be unable to account for how closely he had listened to a conversation about the weather.

They stopped at the crossing while vehicles passed. Water spread from the pavement in shallow, shifting patterns. A bus sent a wave towards them; she stepped back, and he moved the umbrella with her. For a few seconds they stood without speaking.

He could wait. The station would remain where it was. There would be another train. He watched the traffic with the unreasonable hope that it might continue just long enough to spare him the choice of moving on.

Beside him, Sanondita watched for an opening.

She had a journey of her own to finish. He had known that at the classroom door, but knowing it had not prevented him from saying no. Now he stood under her umbrella hoping the traffic would keep her here. She had not complained, and he could not pretend he was responding to impatience. The difficulty was that she seemed willing to do exactly what he had asked.

The vehicles cleared. They crossed together, keeping close enough for the canopy to cover them. On the other side, she adjusted her bag and looked ahead.

“The station isn’t very far now, is it?”

“No.”

“Good.”

He smiled faintly. It was good. They had nearly completed a difficult walk; soon she could turn towards home. He agreed with everything the word meant and still wished she had said something else.

They passed shuttered shops and awnings that shed uneven streams of water. Beneath one, a man held a newspaper over a parcel. Farther ahead, pedestrians followed one another along the narrow edge of a puddle. Utkarsh slowed to let Sanondita find her footing, then did not quite recover their earlier pace.

“Are you all right?” she asked.

“Yes.”

“You’re walking slowly.”

“There’s water everywhere.”

She looked down and nodded. The water was there. It was not the whole answer. He heard how easily he had offered another explanation she had no reason to question.

A gust shook the umbrella. He brought it lower over her head, and water spilled from the edge down his wrist. He wanted to ask whether she would stay a little longer. She might agree. That possibility was more difficult to face than a refusal. He could find another puddle to hesitate before, another practical reason to delay, and she might never realise what he had been asking of her.

He looked at the handle in his hand. It was her umbrella. She had given it to him so that they could get somewhere, and he was using the shelter to wish away their arrival.

He could tell her the truth. That possibility remained, as plain as it had been at the doorway. He was not willing to see her look at his bag and understand. The recognition did not flatter him. Keeping her dry had not made the umbrella inside it disappear.

But he could stop adding minutes to a favour he had never needed. She could go home, and he could finish the short distance himself. The thought was sensible enough. He tightened his grip as though making that decision required him to hold on to something.

The crowd thickened near the station. Voices from the roadside reached them through the rain, and he could make out the direction of the entrance. He turned towards her.

“Sanondita.”

She looked at him. He had wanted the road to last; now he had to use her name to end it.

They stopped where the pavement widened beside a row of shops. People moved past with the hurried determination of those who had been wet for too long. He held the umbrella above them while he found the words.

“You can go from here,” he said. “I’ll manage.”

She glanced ahead. “But the station is still a little farther.”

“I know. It’s all right.”

“Come on. I’ll drop you there.”

For a moment, he could not answer. She had offered the very minutes he was trying to give up. There was nothing he needed to invent now. He could nod, turn with her, and keep walking. He knew where they would step next. He could already imagine looking back on this hesitation with relief that he had accepted.

“No, really. You should go home. It’s raining so much.”

She looked at the sky, then at him.

“That’s why I’m saying I’ll come with you.”

He almost laughed. Even now, she could expose a defect in his reasoning with very little effort. The rain was an excellent reason to take him farther. He had chosen an explanation that supported her argument instead of his own.

There was an answer in his bag, but he could not bring himself to show it to her. He was asking her to trust him again: this time that he would be all right. He wished the first two had deserved the same trust.

"It's not far," he said. "I'll run from here."

"You'll get wet."

"I'm already a little wet."

He made it sound unimportant, turning his right shoulder so she could not see quite how thoroughly it had soaked through. She hesitated.

"Are you sure?"

He nodded.

She looked once more towards the road leading to the station. "I can come. It's fine."

I know.

He looked away. He knew she could. Her willingness had carried them this far, and now it made refusing harder than asking had been. He had wanted to matter enough for her to offer these things easily. Here she was, offering, while he arranged his face to suggest he needed nothing more.

There were only a few minutes left. That made them difficult to surrender. He could see almost the whole of what he was giving up: the next crossing, her voice beneath the canopy, the station entrance approached together. It was small enough that she could offer it without hesitation and large enough that he had to look away before answering.

She had not asked him to end the walk. He could not make the choice hers by pretending otherwise. He wanted her to reach home sooner, and he wanted to stop accepting help obtained through his

lies. Both wishes were real. So was the wish to let her finish speaking and simply say yes.

"Please," he said gently. "Go home. I'll be fine."

She studied him, perhaps deciding whether he was being unnecessarily stubborn.

"You're sure you can manage?"

"Yes."

"Okay, then."

There was no hurt in her voice that he could hear, no disappointment for him to answer. She believed him. For an instant he wanted her to ask once more, though he had just made certain she would stop asking.

He held out the umbrella.

"Here."

She took the handle. He waited until her grip was secure before releasing it. The canopy moved with her, and rain touched the top of his head, then ran cold beneath his collar. A moment earlier, the sound had been above them. Now it was against his face.

"Go quickly, okay?"

"I will."

"Don't stand here."

He nodded. She smiled briefly and turned towards the road home.

He stood there.

She had taken only a few steps. He could call her back, say he had changed his mind, accept the offer before it became too late. His mouth opened a little. He could picture her stopping, turning the umbrella, making room for him again.

Sanondita.

The name remained unspoken. He watched the canopy move away through the rain. Just a little farther, he thought, and then: No. Go home. He was not certain which of them he was addressing.

He had asked her to leave. She was leaving. Nothing had gone wrong in the interval, and yet he stood there wanting to undo it. She

had offered to stay and accepted his refusal. He could find no fault in anything she had done.

A few people passed between them. When they cleared, he could still see her moving carefully around the water near the kerb. His hand went towards the zip of his bag, then stopped. She might turn to check that he was going. He could not bear to be seen opening the umbrella he had said he did not have.

Once she was farther away, he told himself. He would take it out then.

He turned towards the station and began walking quickly. Cold fabric clung to his shoulder; his shoes splashed through the shallow water. He broke into an uneven run. He had told her he would manage, and he would. Reaching the station was a difficulty with a straightforward solution.

He wanted to look back. Instead, he fixed on the entrance ahead. From there, perhaps, he could still see her. He would reach shelter first, turn, and have one last glimpse without risking the impulse to call her over.

For the first time that afternoon, he hurried towards the end of the road.

The pavement soon made running unwise. He slowed where water concealed the uneven ground, listening to the unpleasant sound his shoes made with each step. His own umbrella pressed against his books. By now she would be too far away to see him open it, but the entrance was close; he kept going instead of stopping to reach into the bag. A few more steps seemed easier than admitting how long he had been making that same decision.

He thought of the other handle, still shaped in the curl of his empty fingers. He loosened his hand. The rain was falling on her umbrella somewhere behind him. He wondered whether she had reached the next crossing, whether she was waiting for traffic or making her way past the shops where the pavement narrowed.

He almost turned. Not yet. He had made an arrangement with himself: the station first. Until he looked, he could still imagine her

within sight. He knew how little sense that made. The thought kept him facing forward anyway.

Several people had crowded beneath a tea-stall awning. Steam rose from a kettle and disappeared into the damp air. Someone called across the road. A bicycle bell sounded behind him; he moved aside and let the rider pass. There were other people to make room for, puddles to avoid, the ordinary business of reaching a place.

At the next class, Sanondita might ask whether he had arrived safely. He would say yes. He could imagine the exchange: her question, his answer, a notebook opened between them. She might already be asking about something else while he was still remembering the walk.

He was glad there would be a next class. The thought brought relief, then a smaller ache he had not expected. He would sit beside her again, but he could not return to the moment when she had said she could come and was waiting for him to let her.

He could tell her he had been cold. He could admit that he had wanted to walk more slowly. Those were ordinary things a friend might say. The explanation would become difficult only when he reached the part about why he had sent her home.

Ahead, umbrellas gathered into a restless patchwork at the station. People hurried with bags held against their chests; others stopped beneath the entrance to shake water from their clothes. An announcement drifted from inside, its words blurred by traffic and rain.

He slowed. This was where he had allowed himself to look. He had spent the last few minutes trying to get here, and now he wanted the road to withhold a few more steps.

A man struggled to close an umbrella. Two students argued about which train to catch. A woman brushed past Utkarsh, apologised without stopping, and disappeared into the crowd. He moved out of her way and found himself beneath the shelter of the

entrance. Rain no longer struck his head. Water continued to drip from his hair onto his collar.

He stood for a moment with his back to the road. Then he turned.

Umbrellas moved in both directions. Vehicles edged through water near the crossing. He looked towards the pavement where Sanondita might be, waiting for the people nearest him to clear his view.

A woman stood beneath a dark umbrella. He leaned a little to see past someone, then noticed the child beside her. Farther away, a figure turned a corner before he could make out a face.

He waited. The crowd opened briefly.

Sanondita was not there.

He searched farther along the road, towards the shops they had passed together. Rain blurred the distance. She could have taken another street, or walked farther than he expected while he was making his way here. There was no reason she should still be visible. He knew that and waited for the next gap between umbrellas.

An announcement sounded behind him. Someone brushed his wet sleeve on the way inside. He shifted to let them pass, keeping his eyes on the pavement beyond the crossing.

At the doorway to the classroom, he had needed only to say yes. Beside the shops, when she offered to come farther, he could have said it again. He stood with the bag against his leg, remembering how easily he had found the other word on both occasions.

He looked anyway.

A Little Farther

I turned around beneath the station’s eaves
and searched the crowd for one face, only yours.
Umbrellas drifted by like fallen leaves,
and each one shut me out like closing doors.

“Did you bring yours?” you asked. I answered, “No.”
The lie came out so smooth, so soft, so small.
The one I’d hidden lay there, dry, below
my books. You trusted me. That was all.

You asked me twice if I was sure. I said
I was, and twice you let the matter be.
You did exactly what I asked, instead
of what I hoped you’d do in spite of me.

The rain came through my sleeve and down my arm.
I tilted all the shelter toward your side.
I’d never been so cold, or half so warm,
or so ashamed of what I tried to hide.

How strange, to want you near and send you home,
to spend each step in wishing you would stay,
then use my own voice, steady as a stone,
to ask you, gently, gently, go away.

Once, I pretended I'd forgotten my phone,
to read the notes you held before my eyes.
I wanted one more moment of our own;
how easily I learned those little lies.

"I can come. It's fine," you said, and meant it, too.
That was the thing I could not bear to take:
a kindness, whole, the way you always do,
and me, refusing it, "for your own sake."

I never opened it. I let the rain
have every part of me it chose to claim,
as if a body soaked could ease the pain
of being, so entirely, to blame.

Perhaps you reached the crossing, turned, and saw
the empty place where I had stood in rain,
and felt, for half a breath, some quiet flaw
in the day's shape, then walked on home again.

Call it a kindness. Say I did what's right:
you had a home to reach, a long way round.
But no one warned me what the coming night
would hold, when every road had lost its sound.

I was so gentle with the world today,
with you, the rain, the strangers at my side,
and cruel to one heart only, and the way
I did it left no sign of how it cried.

I hope you reached your home before the night,
that every crossing let you safely through;
that rain grew softer, and the road stayed bright,
and all the gentler weather followed you.

But if time, just once, could grant my plea,
and bring that rain-washed road back into view,
I’d ask for nothing more than what you gave to me—
a little road, a little rain, and you.

I’d wish the station farther down the way,
and borrow one more minute from the glow
of that brief, ordinary, rain-soaked day,
before I find the courage to let you go.

END OF PART ONE

